

Gallup, Inc., 5-13-2026, "Americans Oppose AI Data Centers in Their Area", Gallup,
<https://news.gallup.com/poll/709772/americans-oppose-data-centers-area.aspx>

WASHINGTON, D.C. — **Seven in 10 Americans oppose constructing data centers for artificial intelligence in their local area**, including nearly half, 48%, who are strongly opposed. Barely a quarter favor these projects, with 7% strongly in favor.

Adeel **Hassan 26**. A New York-based reporter for The Times. "The Cloud Has Sound: The Unrelenting and Unseen Cost of A.I. Data Centers". 6-17-2026. *The New York Times*.

<https://www.nytimes.com/2026/06/17/us/data-centers-noise-pollution.html?searchResultPosition=5>.
elimafia 

The heartbeat of the artificial intelligence economy sounds like a low-frequency thrum of a neighbor's central air-conditioning unit, an airplane flying overhead at high altitude or a truck engine idling down the road.

But it feels like **the vibrating, rhythmic pulse of a subwoofer from a party that will never end**.

Yes, the cloud has a sound, and some who live closest to data centers that emit the noise have reached their wit's end trying to block it out. Residents in three small cities last month filed lawsuits against data centers specifically about noise.

The United States has more than 3,000 operational data centers, with more than 1,500 in development, according to a Pew Research Center analysis. They have been the backbone of the information economy for decades, operating largely in the background of daily life.

The boxy industrial facilities house thousands of servers and chips to process billions of operations daily and store vast amounts of data. The memory chips generate heat and they need giant industrial fans to keep them from melting. Many data centers also use diesel-powered generators since the grid often can't support such heavy power needs.

The demands of artificial intelligence, which require far greater amounts of computing power and cooling infrastructure, have led to a burst of data center construction.

Today, **nearly 40 percent of homes are within five miles of at least one operational data center**. Pew found, and more of them are creeping closer.

The humming of those cooling systems, the rumbling of the generators and the **whirring of fans can be heard, and felt, for hundreds of feet and even up to a mile away.**

NWS, xx-xx-20**26**, "Global Billionaire Count Hits Record 3,302 in UBS Report", Net Worth,
<https://networth.us/ubs-global-wealth-report-2026-billionaire-population-record-ai-semiconductor/>

Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang's wealth trajectory encapsulates the structural shift from software to hardware that is reshaping the global wealth pyramid. Forbes estimates Huang's **net worth** at **over \$200 billion** as of mid-2026, making him the seventh-wealthiest individual in the world. That figure represents roughly a 37-fold increase over six years, driven entirely by his approximately 3.3% stake in Nvidia — not by salary, bonuses, or diversified business ventures. The wealth acceleration is anchored to Nvidia's commercial dominance of the AI accelerator chip market. Nvidia reported fiscal year 2026 revenue of \$215.9 billion, with \$62.3 billion coming from its Data Center division in the most recent quarter alone — a 73% increase from the same period the prior year. **Nvidia became the first public company to sustain a \$5 trillion market capitalization, a milestone that directly inflated Huang's paper wealth.**

Jim Vandehei, Mike **Allen**, 1-11-20**26**, "Behind the Curtain: The Haves, Have-Nots, Have-Lots economy", Axios, <https://www.axios.com/2026/01/12/ai-winners-wealth-inequality>

The nation is splitting into three distinct economic realities: the Have-Nots (stalling) ... the Haves (coasting) ... and the Have-Lots (rocketing to greater wealth). Why it matters: This isn't just about "inequality." **It's about a structural shift where the growing number of hyperwealthy are profiting wildly off the AI revolution — through exclusive access to private deals, massive investment power, governmental connections, and equity stakes that "normal" investors can't touch.** The big picture: This shift, if it holds, will rattle economics, politics and AI throughout 2026 and beyond. We're already seeing it in rising inequality, pessimism about the future and AI opposition. It's human nature to judge your personal economics and mood on how you feel, influenced heavily by conscious and subconscious comparisons to others. So it's possible President Trump is right: U.S. growth and stocks soar in 2026. But even then, because the AI-connected hyperwealthy do so much better than everyone else, fear and resentment still grow. It's also possible the AI bubble pops, and everyone suffers. But the Have-Lots will (mostly) still have lots. The Have-Nots: Stuck For the bottom 50%+, the economy, by historical standards, is fine. Wages are growing, unemployment is low, and inflation is moderate. But the mood is sour, as shown by sky-high pessimism about their personal future and AI. This group leans Trump — not massively, but clearly, and enough to matter to MAGA's plans. Their income is up about 4% year-over-year before inflation, lower than the growth for their richer friends. But they're often burning through any increase to keep pace with inflation for food and energy. If they don't own a house, rents are high. And mortgage rates are around 6%, nearly twice what friends and neighbors got five years ago. The surging stock market does little for them. **The bottom 50% of Americans own a measly 1% of all U.S. stocks. When Nvidia or Microsoft adds \$1 trillion in market cap, it does nothing for the bank accounts of half the country.** Roughly 40% of Americans couldn't cover a \$400 emergency expense without debt. So it's no wonder working-class or lower-income Americans are downbeat, and fear AI wiping away their jobs or making matters worse. The gap: **During the AI bounce of the past two years, the top 10% of households saw their wealth increase by \$5 trillion in a single quarter (Q2 2025), while the bottom 50% saw a gain of just \$150 billion.** The Haves: Coasting (nervously) We're talking about roughly a third of U.S. households with \$100,000+ in investable assets. They're disproportionately likely to own stocks and retirement accounts. If they're homeowners, many are still enjoying low mortgage rates from 2020–21. By most historical measures, they're doing pretty well. Their wages rose 4.4% and they enjoyed strong market returns in 2025. About 54% of homeowners are sitting on mortgage rates at or below 4%. Those amount to golden handcuffs, keeping housing costs down for those who bought their home before 2022, even as today's 6%+ mortgage rates keep current renters out of the market. Bank of America data shows holiday spending grew much more strongly among higher-income households than lower-income ones. But many are AI-nervous. They tend to hold white-collar jobs threatened by high-performing AI, and read daily about the tough job market for their college-age or soon-to-be college-age kids. The lower end of the affluent benefit from broad-based market gains, thanks to AI or AI-adjacent companies. But most aren't putting money directly into the AI startups fueling the hyper wealth growth of the Have-Lots. The University of Michigan's consumer sentiment survey, released Friday, actually found improvement this month "among lower-income consumers, while sentiment fell for those with higher incomes." The Have-Lots: Rocketing A new AI aristocracy is upon us. The tech moguls, mega-investors and others benefiting from AI are now in a category of their own that vastly overshadows the mere haves.

Cat **Zakrzewski** is a White House reporter for The Washington Post. Send her secure tips on Signal at cqz.17. She previously covered tech policy and was the founding anchor of The Technology 202 newsletter. Before joining The Post in 2018, she was a venture capital reporter for the Wall Street Journal, 8-27-2026, "Trump champions data centers as Republicans turn against them", archive.ph, <https://archive.ph/fEoKz>

As voters in both parties grow anxious about the rapid build-out of data centers, President Donald Trump remains one of the tech industry's most prominent champions — putting him increasingly at odds with members of his own party. Nowhere is that divergence clearer than in Texas, where Trump travels Thursday to campaign for Ken Paxton, the state's attorney general and Republican Senate candidate. The state has courted some of the country's biggest data center projects, but now Paxton and Gov. Greg Abbott (R) have moved to address voters' concerns about the centers' potential to raise power costs and disrupt neighborhoods, with Abbott pausing new projects from connecting to the state's power grid and Paxton endorsing his approach. Days after Abbott imposed the pause, Trump called the Texas governor's resistance to data centers "a mistake." The rift highlights a rare policy issue where Republicans are willing to break openly with the White House. **Trump has made accelerating data centers a signature priority, signing an executive order last year that expedites federal permitting,**

facilitates construction on federal land and makes qualifying projects eligible for financial incentives.

He has hosted tech leaders in the Oval Office to celebrate multibillion-dollar deals for new data

centers. And even as more members of his party turn against them, **he repeatedly defends the rise of**

the tech infrastructure in public comments and interviews. <<<image omitted>>> “If I were the mayor of a town

or the governor of a state, and I had a chance to get a big plant in an AI plant or a data center, I would absolutely want it because the jobs are enormous, and the money paid, the taxes paid are just enormous,” Trump said last week, surrounded by leaders from the crypto industry. “And if you don’t take it, you’re going to be left behind because there are plenty of places that want it.” A national survey conducted Aug. 21-24 by the Economist and YouGov found that 51 percent of Americans disagree with the president’s assessment, including 41 percent of respondents who identified as conservatives. The poll also found that 61 percent of Americans opposed construction of a data center in their community, including 47 percent of Republicans. More than half of people who voted for Trump in the 2024 election said that a

new data center in their community would increase their electricity costs — a concern supported by

evidence that the facilities’ enormous power demands can raise wholesale prices and leave other

customers paying for grid upgrades. How much consumers actually pay depends on how regulators and utilities allocate those costs, but the fear that ordinary people will get stuck with the bill has fueled increasingly pitched political fights across the country. “Opinions on data centers have gone south so fast, faster than anything I’ve ever seen,” said Brent Buchanan, the founder and CEO of the Republican polling firm Cygnal. “Voters are looking for someone to stand up and say, ‘I have your interests above these tech companies. I have your interests above these data center companies. I have your interests above AI.’” A White House official said that the president wants data centers to be built only in communities that want them. On Friday, Trump said Republican candidates do not need to take the same position as him on data centers. “I want them to do what they want,” Trump said on Friday. “Some people feel differently. I really want them — if a Republican is against the data center, that’s okay with me.” Trump’s support for the tech industry could complicate Republicans’ ability to sell that message to voters as they head to the polls. Democrats have launched ads attacking candidates who they say are receiving funds from donors tied to the tech industry and Trump. The artificial intelligence boom has been central to many of Trump’s talking points about his economic accomplishments, including historic stock market highs and companies’ large investments in the U.S. economy. <<<image omitted>>> **Trump’s data center**

policies were influenced by a cohort of tech leaders who were prominent donors to his campaign. He

signed the executive order that encouraged the build-out of data centers last year at an event with the

co-hosts of the “All In” podcast, a show hosted by several prominent tech investors, including former

White House AI and crypto czar David Sacks. Sacks and Sriram Krishnan, a former White House official

and venture capitalist, were also among the authors of the administration’s AI Action Plan, which

outlined ways to expedite environmental permitting for data centers. Trump has also expressed a fear of

supporting regulation that could hold back the artificial intelligence industry, saying the United States

could lose its edge to China. A wave of Chinese models released in July has increased concerns that U.S.

companies could lose their lead over rivals. **“Trump just personally cares about this topic,”** said a person

familiar with his thinking, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe private conversations.

“You just can’t change his mind about it.” Over the past year, the White House has sought to respond to

the growing backlash to data centers by touting a “ratepayer protection pledge” that would require

major tech companies to generate their own energy for data centers, pay for grid upgrades and protect

consumers from rising electricity bills. However, the pledge is voluntary and does not specify

consequences for companies if they do not comply.

Lindwall 26 [Courtney Lindwall, 6-24-2026, "The AI Boom Is Stressing the Grid—but It Doesn’t Have to Be This Way", No Publication,

<https://www.nrdc.org/stories/ai-boom-stressing-grid-it-doesnt-have-be-way>] scarman

By comparison, **large data centers are massive, centralized loads that, for the most part, draw power**

around the clock. This constant, concentrated demand can strain or even **overwhelm the grid and**

increase the risk of **blackouts**. Such outages also tend to happen just when people need power the most, like during heat waves or storms.

Doe, 12-20-2024, "DOE Releases New Report Evaluating Increase in Electricity Demand from Data Centers", Energy.gov,
<https://www.energy.gov/articles/doe-releases-new-report-evaluating-increase-electricity-demand-data-centers>

WASHINGTON, D.C. — The U.S. Department of Energy (DOE) today announced the publication of the 2024 Report on U.S. Data Center Energy Use produced by Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory (LBNL) which outlines the energy use of data centers from 2014 to 2028. The report estimates that **data center load growth has tripled over the past decade and is projected to** double or triple **by 2028**. U.S. electricity demand is projected to account for data center expansion and the rise of artificial intelligence (AI) applications, domestic manufacturing growth, and electrification of different industries. DOE has anticipated this growing demand trend — it reflects robust industrial investments in America and national leadership on technology innovation. The Department continues to develop advanced technologies and leverage its resources to meet rising electricity demand in the United States while maintaining a reliable, affordable, and secure national energy system.

Goldman Sachs 26 [Goldman Sachs, is one of the largest investment banks in the world by revenue[2] and is ranked 32nd on the Fortune 500 list of the largest United States corporations by total revenue 5-20-2026, "US Data Center Power Demand Projected to Double by 2027", No Publication,
<https://www.goldmansachs.com/insights/articles/us-data-center-power-demand-projected-to-double-by-2027>] scarman

US data center power demand is forecast to more than double to 66 GW in 2027 from 31 GW in 2025, driven by an accelerating buildout of AI infrastructure, according to Goldman Sachs Commodities Research. Only about 50-60% of data center capacity scheduled for the next one to two years is expected to come online on time amid delays and cancellations. Regional impacts will diverge sharply, with Mid-Atlantic, Mid-Continent, and Northwest markets facing elevated reliability risks, while the impact in Texas and Georgia may be relatively marginal thanks to plans for additional power generation. **Data centers'** share of total US peak summer power demand is projected to jump to 8.5% in 2027 from 4.1% in 2025, creating significant tightening across the national power market. A wave of new data center **construction**, fueled by surging demand for artificial intelligence (AI) computing, is on track to more than **double the power used by US data centers within two years**, according to Goldman Sachs Research. What is the forecast for data center power demand? US data center power demand is expected to climb from 31 gigawatts (GW) in 2025 to 41 GW in 2026 and 66 GW the year after, write Hongcen Wei, Daan Struyven, and Samantha Dart from the commodities team in Goldman Sachs Research. This demand forecast is based on the estimate that US data center capacity will increase to roughly 95 GW by the end of 2027, more than doubling the level at the end of 2025, and a capacity utilization rate assumption of 70%.

MGS 24 (Midwest Generator Solutions, 8-1-2024, "Gridlock: America's Aging Power Infrastructure and You",
<https://midwestgeneratorsolutions.com/americas-aging-power-infrastructure-and-you/>) // scarman

Frequent **power outages** are becoming the **new normal**. But they're simply a symptom of a much larger problem: **the aging and neglected** state of the U.S. power grid. The term "power grid" or "electricity grid" refers to the intricate network of power plants, transmission lines, and distribution systems that deliver electricity to our homes and businesses. Much of **this infrastructure**, however, **was built in the mid-20th century**, making it an **aging infrastructure that is prone to outages and vulnerable to attack**. These aging power infrastructure problems contribute to a host of issues. Problems that Arise with an Aging Power Grid This extends beyond simple inconvenience. **Decades of wear and tear have left the power grid vulnerable to** a multitude of threats. The impact of an aging power grid **that is past its prime, prone to malfunctions and failures is far-reaching**. Without intervention, **the inevitable failure of the current power grid will spark an energy crisis** that threatens our national security, economic stability, and American way of life. Power grid reliability issues then become a constant worry, as these breakdowns can cascade throughout the system, triggering power outages that leave entire communities in the dark. This lack of power grid maintenance is a ticking time bomb, increasing the risk of not just localized blackouts, but potentially even a power grid collapse, a scenario that would have catastrophic consequences. Frequent power outages are another problem that goes along with an old power grid. The frequency with which power grid blackouts are increasing isn't just an inconvenience; it's a symptom of a deeper illness. Imagine the doctor performing a critical surgery plunged into darkness, the CEO losing crucial data during a presentation due to a sudden power surge, or entire production lines grinding to a halt in factories. The impact of power outages on the economy and human flourishing can be devastating, with businesses losing revenue, productivity plummeting and human lives being endangered. The vulnerabilities of the aging power grid extend beyond physical breakdowns. Power grid security is a growing concern as the system becomes increasingly reliant on digital control systems, which can be compromised by both cyber and electromagnetic pulse attacks. Malicious actors, both foreign and domestic, are constantly seeking new ways to exploit these weaknesses. The effects of power grid cyberattacks would cripple entire regions, plunging millions into darkness and causing widespread chaos. These dire consequences highlight the urgent need to bolster our cyber defenses and build a more secure power grid. When it comes to the power grid, the threats aren't all man-made... Climate change and the power grid are intricately linked. Extreme weather power outages have become more frequent due climate change and can cause major damage to our power infrastructure.

National Academies of Sciences, Engineering, and Medicine. 2012. Terrorism and the Electric Power Delivery System. Washington, DC: The National Academies Press. <https://doi.org/10.17226/12050>.

A terrorist attack on the power system would lack the dramatic impact of the attacks in New York, Madrid, or London. It would not immediately kill many people or make for spectacular television footage of bloody destruction. But if it were carried out in a carefully planned way, by people who knew what they were doing, it could deny large regions of the country access to bulk system power for weeks or even months. An event of this magnitude and duration could lead to turmoil, widespread public fear, and an image of helplessness that would play directly into the hands of the terrorists. If such **large extended outages** were to occur during times of extreme weather, **they could also result in hundreds or even thousands of deaths due to heat stress or extended exposure to extreme cold**.

Ari **Peskoe 25**. Director of the Electricity Law Initiative @ the Harvard Law School Environmental and Energy Law Program. "How data centers may lead to higher electricity bills". 9-3-2025. *Harvard Law Today*. <https://hls.harvard.edu/today/how-data-centers-may-lead-to-higher-electricity-bills/>. elimafia 

Peskoe: There are **two ways that data centers can raise rates for everyone**. **First, the utility is building new infrastructure** to provide energy to data centers and **spreads those costs** to all ratepayers. Second, certain energy prices that the utility pays are set through markets, and when demand goes up — and supply doesn't go up fast enough to meet it — prices go up.

I'll explain how each one works. **When a utility builds infrastructure** like poles and wires or power plants, **it socializes that cost across all users**. That's been the business model for a century, and it's generally seen as a fair way to do things. For example, if there's a tree that falls down and hits a power line in your neighborhood and the power goes out, the utility sends a truck and workers to fix it, but it doesn't bill you for the repair. Instead, it includes the repair costs in the rates that are paid by everyone. Similarly, if there's residential growth across the utility's monopoly service territory, and the utility therefore must build hundreds of millions of dollars of new infrastructure

for the new businesses and residents, that cost is spread to everyone. The utility is going to have to build a lot of new infrastructure to be able to generate power and deliver that power. Everyone is going to bear some of that cost. Because data centers consume so much power, utilities are building billions of dollars of new power lines and power plants to supply these industrial-scale facilities. The utility's traditional approach of spreading infrastructure costs across all ratepayers forces us to pay for costs that the utility incurs only because of the computing facilities.

The other way is, as I said, in many parts of the country, utilities purchase electricity through markets, and those prices are going up because demand is going up in the market, and it takes a while to build new power plants. New industrial computing facilities are causing demand to rise faster than supply. The utility pays more for energy, and accordingly, all consumers pay more.

HLT: If part of the problem is demand for electricity exceeding supply, why don't utilities just work on increasing supply?

Peskoe: The industry is working to bring more supply online. For a number of reasons, building and connecting new power plants to the system takes too long. The reasons range from supply chain bottlenecks to lengthy studies conducted by utilities prior to connection.

HLT: For their part, those developing these data centers are saying that they will bear the cost of the infrastructure upgrades, but in your paper, you argue that this can be difficult to verify. Why is that?

Peskoe: We all pay electricity prices that are set through rate cases, which are determined via public proceedings where various parties participate and provide evidence to regulators. The utility commission issues a decision in writing that can then be reviewed by a court. Many data centers do not pay those prices. They sign contracts with a utility that provides a special deal, and typically, those contracts are confidential to the public. They're only available to the utility regulators and anybody that participates in the proceedings to review that contract, if there is one at all. Some states don't review those contracts.

The reason we should be skeptical that data centers are paying an appropriate rate is because in these proceedings, if there are any, the regulators are only hearing from the utility and the data center. If you're only hearing one side, there's no counterargument and the proceeding is biased in favor of the utility and the data center. The other reason to be skeptical here is that regulators exist in a political environment where many state legislatures and state governors support data center investment because they're billion-dollar facilities that can bring a lot of construction jobs and sometimes local tax revenue. It can be a big political risk for a utility regulator to reject a deal like this.

ECR 26 [EveryCRSReport, 9-1-2026, "Data Centers and the Electricity Grid: Frequently Asked Questions", No Publication, <https://www.everycrsreport.com/reports/R49326.html>]

Although the studies discussed above found only a limited effect of data centers on electricity prices in the past, data centers could have a greater impact on prices as the industry continues to grow and demand more electricity. In electricity markets with little spare generation capacity, the added demand of data centers may increase the future price of electricity for all customers. This appears to be one of several contributing factors to electricity price increases in 2025 and 2026 in the PJM region, a part of the country that includes "Data Center Alley" in northern Virginia (see Figure 1).⁵³ A recent modeling study led by North Carolina State University found that data centers (and cryptocurrency mining facilities) could cause national average electricity costs to increase by 6% to 29%, across different modeling scenarios, with increases up to 57% in some regions.⁵⁴ Another modeling study led by Carnegie Mellon University found that "data center and cryptocurrency mining growth through 2030

could increase average U.S. electricity generation costs by 8%."55 Whether electricity costs rise due to data centers, and by how much, would vary by region and depend on assumptions about market response. The potential price impacts on electricity customers in any market area remain uncertain.

Mark **Wolfe 23**. Executive Director of the National Energy Assistance Directors Association. "Energy poverty in America: a never-ending emergency". 3-25-2023. *The Hill*.

<https://thehill.com/opinion/energy-environment/3918051-energy-poverty-in-america-a-never-ending-emergency/>. elimafia 

The way we pay for residential energy in this country is failing our most vulnerable families. We all need energy for our homes, but price fluctuations can make energy unaffordable for many. As energy prices increase, families fall further behind on their utility bills. The national total amount of money families are behind on their electric and gas bills is about \$16.6 billion almost double the level prior to the beginning of the pandemic. Nearly 20.8 million households owe on average \$791, up slightly from June 2022 when the total amount owed stood at about \$16.3 billion and the average amount owed was about \$783.

When families cannot afford the cost of home energy, they take drastic measures to stay connected to the energy grid. The U.S. Census Bureau's most recent Household Pulse Survey reported that nearly 47 percent of families earning less than \$50,000 reduced their spending on food or medicine at least once in the last year to pay their home energy bills, up from 46.6 percent the previous year.

And when those drastic measures are not enough, families face disconnection of utility services. An estimated 4.2 million households were disconnected in the first 10 months of 2022, an increase of 29 percent in electric and 76 percent in natural gas connections as compared to the same period in 2021. And for those using delivered fuels — heating oil and propane — dealers simply won't deliver more fuel unless they receive payment up-front.

Michael **Blackhurst 25**. PhD in Civil and Environmental Engineering/Engineering and Public Policy @ Carnegie Mellon University. "Data Center Growth Could Increase Electricity Bills 8% Nationally and as Much as 25% in Some Regional Markets". June 2025. *Carnegie Mellon University*.

<https://www.cmu.edu/work-that-matters/energy-innovation/data-center-growth-could-increase-electricity-bills>. elimafia 

New modeling from the Open Energy Outlook Initiative shows that data center and cryptocurrency mining growth through 2030 could increase average U.S. electricity generation costs by 8% and greenhouse gas emissions from power generation by 30%.

Why it matters: Absent policy action, this increase in demand for electricity generation could lead to dramatically higher electricity bills for consumers and undermine the nation's clean energy goals.

For example, capacity market prices in the nation's largest grid operator (PJM) exploded in December 2024, from \$30 to \$270 per megawatt-day (MW-day), a ninefold rise that will increase bills for 67 million customers across 13 states.

Catch up quick: Traditional utility planning assumes predictable 1%-2% annual demand growth over decades, but data centers are driving regional growth rates of 20%-30% annually. This mismatch between conventional planning timelines and demand growth has exposed limitations in capacity planning practices and increased short-run electricity generation costs, with some markets heavily utilizing older and more costly fossil-fuel generators in the short run.

What we did: The Open Energy Outlook (OEO) Initiative, a collaboration between Carnegie Mellon University and North Carolina State University, modeled the energy and emissions implications of expected data center and cryptocurrency mine growth. The analysis models the infrastructure, economic, and environmental implications under current policies and recommends policy tools that could ensure the grid accommodates this expansion while protecting consumers and climate goals.

What we found: Recent model results show that rapid data center demand growth increases generation from aging and expensive coal-fired power generators. In contrast, Texas utilizes more wind generation through targeted transmission investments. These contrasting outcomes underscore that data center growth will drive different regional outcomes.

Other key findings from the modeling include:

Regional cost surge: Central and Northern Virginia face projected 2030 electricity cost increases exceeding 25%, the highest regional increase in the model.

Coal gets lifeline: More than 25 GW of aging coal plants otherwise scheduled for retirement would continue operating primarily to serve data center demand.

Emissions spike: Power sector emissions could increase 30% compared to scenarios without data center growth, reaching 275 million metric tonnes of CO2 annually by 2030. That matches the entire annual carbon output of France.

Carbon leakage: Virginia's data center growth drives increased fossil fuel use in nearby states like Ohio, Pennsylvania, and West Virginia, potentially undermining state and regional climate goals.

Policy takeaways: There are several state and federal policy strategies to consider that may mitigate the effects of this expected growth, such as:

Fair cost allocation: Create new customer classes and revenue sharing mechanisms to ensure large users rather than families pay for elevated infrastructure costs.

Strategic siting incentives: Incentivize data center expansions in renewable-rich regions and away from areas dependent on fossil fuel generation.

Transmission acceleration: Improving permitting and cost allocation for transmission lines connecting renewable resources to demand centers.

Demand flexibility requirements: Incentivize or require energy efficiency or load management during peak periods or emergencies.

What's next: Data center and crypto mining electricity demand is projected to grow 350% by 2030. Without intervention, the pattern seen in PJM — massive price spikes followed by political backlash — will become more frequent. Continued investment in energy systems modeling resources like those maintained by the Open Energy Outlook Initiative can help identify policy interventions that balance the benefits and costs of increased data server activity.

The bottom line: The digital infrastructure boom is outpacing our electricity system's ability to respond. Data centers offer potential benefits but risk locking in higher emissions and driving up prices for households without proactive and coordinated planning. Policymakers must act now to align infrastructure investment and regulation with this demand surge.

Green 25 [Ben Green; Assistant Professor, School of Information and Gerald R. Ford School of Public Policy at the University of Michigan, July 2025, "WHAT HAPPENS WHEN DATA CENTERS COME TO TOWN?", No Publication, <https://stpp.fordschool.umich.edu/sites/stpp/files/2025-07/stpp-data-centers-2025.pdf>] //alay

The impossibility of an environmentally friendly data center Data centers cannot fully operate on renewable energy alone. Renewable energy sources like solar and wind are inconsistent and cannot meet the uptime (time during which a machine, especially a computer, is in operation) requirements of data centers. Tier 1 data centers require 99.671% uptime while Tier 4s demand 99.995%. These factors make it impossible for data centers to depend solely on renewables without compromising reliability. As demand for cloud computing and AI-driven technologies accelerates, data

centers are being constructed at a rapid pace, often in areas where existing power infrastructure is insufficient to meet their enormous energy needs. **To ease concerns** about environmental impact, **data center** operators frequently **pledge** that **their facilities will eventually run on clean energy**, including next-generation nuclear sources such as small modular reactors (SMRs). However, these SMRs remain largely theoretical, with no commercially viable models yet in operation.⁷ In the interim, companies **claim** they will rely on **fossil fuels** as a **temporary “bridge”** until greener solutions become available. **Yet in practice, this transition is often delayed or abandoned altogether**, resulting in the **direct commissioning of new fossil fuel power plants to keep these facilities online**. This gap between promise and reality underscores the fundamental contradiction in labeling data centers as “environmentally friendly.” Battery storage is essential for balancing the intermittent nature of renewable energy generation, but batteries rapidly degrade and are reliant on rare minerals like lithium, nickel, cobalt, manganese, lead, and copper. These minerals are already in short supply due to high demand from the electric vehicle industry. Data centers will also always have an environmental footprint through material resource consumption, water usage, and electricity demands. This makes it unfeasible for them to be completely environmentally friendly.

Michael **Blackhurst** 25. PhD in Civil and Environmental Engineering/Engineering and Public Policy @ Carnegie Mellon University. "Data Center Growth Could Increase Electricity Bills 8% Nationally and as Much as 25% in Some Regional Markets". June 2025. *Carnegie Mellon University*.
<https://www.cmu.edu/work-that-matters/energy-innovation/data-center-growth-could-increase-electricity-bills>. elimafia 

Catch up quick: **Traditional utility planning assumes** predictable **1%-2%** annual demand **growth** over decades, but **data centers** are **driving regional growth rates of 20%-30% annually**. This **mismatch between conventional planning timelines and demand growth** has **exposed limitations in capacity planning practices** and **increased short-run electricity generation costs**, with some **markets heavily utilizing older and more costly fossil-fuel generators** in the short run.

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Emissions spike: **Power sector emissions could increase 30%** compared to scenarios without data center growth, **reaching 275 million metric tonnes of CO2 annually by 2030**. That **matches the entire annual carbon output of France**.

Carbon leakage: Virginia's data center growth drives increased fossil fuel use in nearby states like Ohio, Pennsylvania, and West Virginia, potentially undermining state and regional climate goals.

Policy takeaways: There are several state and federal policy strategies to consider that may mitigate the effects of this expected growth, such as:

Emission kills. (226 * 275 = 62k deaths)

Daniel Bressler 21. Columbia University School of International and Public Affairs, New York, NY, USA "The mortality cost of carbon". 7-28-2021. *Nature Communications*.

<https://www.nature.com/articles/s41467-021-24487-w>. elimafia 

Like the SCC, the MCC is useful for determining the social impact of new marginal activities or projects that produce greenhouse emissions, or, equivalently, the benefit from forgoing these activities. In the central estimate, we find that the 2020 MCC is 2.26×10^{-4} lives per metric ton as shown in Table 1, with the low (<10th percentile) to high (>90th percentile) estimate ranging from -1.71×10^{-4} to 6.78×10^{-4} (see the "Methods" section for more details on the uncertainty in the mortality estimate). This implies that reducing (increasing) emissions by 1 million metric tons of carbon dioxide in 2020 saves 226 lives (causes 226 excess deaths) in expectation from 2020 to 2100 in the baseline emissions scenario. One million metric tons is roughly equal to the average annual emissions of 35 commercial airliners, 216,000 passenger vehicles, and 115,000 homes in the United States. The MCC implies that removing (adding) a year's worth of carbon dioxide emissions from an average coal-fired powerplant in the United States in 2020 saves 904 lives (causes 904 excess deaths) in expectation from 2020 to 2100 (refs. 57,58).

Bommarito '26 [Michael; researcher, adjunct professor, and serial technology entrepreneur at Stanford University; 2-15-2026; "Moratorium Nation: A Survey of Data Center, Renewable Energy, and Battery Storage Moratoria in the United States"; ALEA Institute;

https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=6242898; DOA: 7-12-2026] shaan + BZ recut shang

Study Obligation

A moratorium is a means to an end—the adoption of permanent, well-considered regulations—not an end in itself. Courts in every jurisdiction that has addressed the question have held that a moratorium is invalid if the government simply pauses development without undertaking the studies it promised. The Minnesota Supreme Court established this principle in *Almquist v. Town of Marshan* (*Almquist v. Town of Marshan* 1976). Under *Almquist*, a moratorium is valid only if enacted in good faith and of limited duration. The enacting body must “proceed promptly” with the study and “expeditiously” adopt appropriate ordinances upon completion.

The Tahoe-Sierra majority explicitly noted that the outcome might have been different without evidence that the agency “acted diligently and in good faith.” A municipality that adopts a moratorium and then takes no action forfeits its strongest defense. No consultants retained, no studies commissioned, no draft regulations prepared—such inaction removes all legal armor. Several state statutes codify this obligation: California requires a written progress report ten days before the moratorium expires (Cal. Gov’t Code § 65858); North Carolina prohibits extensions unless “all reasonable and feasible steps” have been taken (N.C.G.S. § 160D-107).

Congress 26. "Artificial Intelligence Data Center Moratorium Act". 3-25-2026.

<https://www.congress.gov/bill/119th-congress/senate-bill/4214/text>. elimafia 

Moratorium.—Beginning on the date of enactment of this Act, the construction or upgrading of new or existing artificial intelligence data centers may not commence or proceed until—

(1) 1 or more laws are enacted that ensure that—

(A) the Federal Government shall review and approve artificial intelligence products before those products are released, for the purpose of ensuring that those products are safe and effective and do not threaten the health and well-being of working families, privacy and civil rights, and the future of humanity;

(B) the economic gains of artificial intelligence and robotics will benefit workers, not just the wealthy owners of Big Tech companies, including by—

- (i) putting policies in place to prevent job displacement due to artificial intelligence; and
 - (ii) ensuring the wealth generated by those companies is shared with the people of the United States; and
- (C) with respect to any artificial intelligence data center built or upgraded after the termination of the moratorium under this subsection—
- (i) the artificial intelligence data center does not increase utility or electricity bills of consumers;
 - (ii) the artificial intelligence data center does not exacerbate the threat of climate change or harm the environment;
 - (iii) communities that would be affected by the artificial intelligence data center are empowered to approve or reject the construction or upgrading of that artificial intelligence data center;
 - (iv) no government subsidy is provided for the construction, upgrading, or operation of that artificial intelligence data center; and
 - (v) the artificial intelligence data center creates union jobs with strong labor standards, including payment of prevailing wage